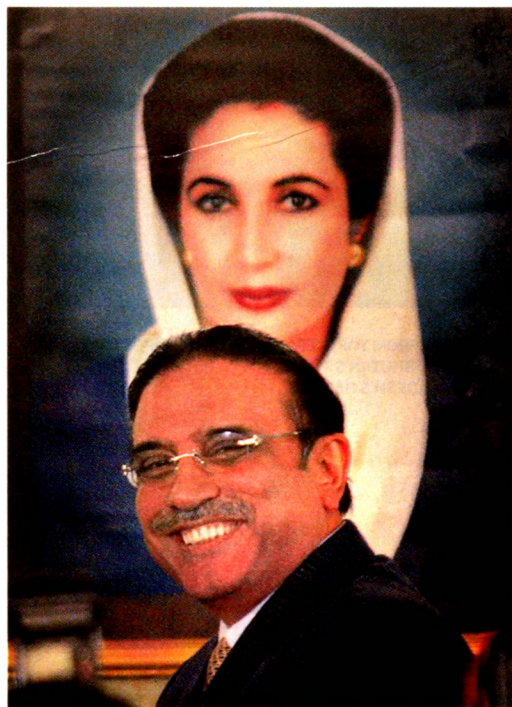




MANMOHAN SINGH WITH
GEORGE BUSH (LEFT);
PAKISTAN'S ASIF ALI ZARDARI



REUTERS

AFP

US Congress put its seal on the deal in record time, proving not only the bipartisan support that India has among American lawmakers but also the great importance they place in improving relations between the two countries. Finally, Manmohan, showing political savvy, won a trust vote in Parliament which ensured that he kept his side of the bargain.

For Manmohan, it should have gone down as the year of a great foreign policy triumph, with the theme song being the Bollywood hit "*Singh is King*". Instead, by the end of 2008, India was being shown the boundaries of its new-found stature when after the Mumbai attacks, there was a growing frustration on how to deal with a recalcitrant Pakistan. India had a binary choice: either a

military response which the world feared could result in a nuclear confrontation with Pakistan or bank on international pressure to bring Islamabad to heel. Neither of these are the best to have when confronted with the gravest internal security threat the nation faces in recent times. The hyphenation with Pakistan that India fought for years to end was threatening to return with Barack Obama taking over as US President and pushing for a regional policy.

Clearly, India had failed to cash in on the momentum it had built in the previous years not only by its extraordinary economic growth but also by pushing for a brave new relationship with the US. India had the chance then to amicably settle its relations with

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